Directory of Departments and Agencies

Find your area of responsibility in East Detroit's digital government spec

Public Mechanics
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The 27 entries

Pick one entry and claim it on the Sign-up Sheet. The instructor plays every entry nobody claims.

- **D-01 to D-15** are city-county departments. They must take part, though they can object and set conditions.
- **A-01 to A-09** are outside agencies with their own boards, budgets and records. Each can join the exchange, join on conditions, or refuse. A-09 takes part only if a student claims it.
- **R-01 to R-03** are resident groups. They don't run services; they test whether the system works for the people it serves.

Where an entry is modeled on a real institution, the entry says so.

What "a city-county Estonia" means

Estonia's government agencies exchange data through a shared layer called X-tee (formerly X-Road in English). According to Estonia's Information System Authority:

- Each member keeps its own records, describes the data it is willing to share, and lets other members use it under an agreement.
- The owner controls its data throughout. The exchange layer only carries messages.
- Every exchange is authenticated, authorized at several levels, encrypted, signed and logged.
- To use another member's data, an organization joins, installs a security server, and signs an agreement with that member.

Every entry has to answer four questions for the spec:

1. What records does it hold that others need?
2. What does it need from others?
3. Will it join, and on what terms?
4. Who corrects a wrong record, and where does a resident appeal?

Each entry's "Questions for the spec" are the place to start. You answer them, or negotiate them.

Find your area

Table 1. Topics and the entries that own them

If you care about…	Look at
Housing, rent, eviction, homelessness	D-05, A-06, A-07, D-04, R-01
Addresses, maps, parcels, records that don’t match	D-07, D-08, D-06, R-02
Benefits, food and cash assistance, appeals	D-04, A-05, D-15
Schools, children and families	A-01, D-07, D-04
Health care, hospitals, ambulances	A-08, A-09, D-12, D-11
Emergencies, 911, police, fire	D-10, D-11, D-07, A-08
Transit, roads, getting around	A-04, D-14, R-03
Water, sewer, growth, land use	A-03, D-06, D-14, R-02
Courts, legal process, protection orders	A-07, D-15, D-05
Libraries, internet access, help for people without phones	A-02, D-13, R-03
Money, budgets, taxes, buying technology	D-08, D-02, D-03
Running the exchange itself, privacy, security	D-09, D-15, D-03
Politics, priorities, final approval	D-01, D-02, D-03
Fairness, language access, disability access	D-15, R-03, R-01

Table 2. Test households and the entries they involve

Test household (Reading 1)	Entries most involved
H01: renters in Colfax East; hourly schedule changes weekly	D-04, D-05, D-09, A-05, R-01
H02: retired homeowner in Old Watkins; rural address doesn’t match GIS	D-07, D-08, D-15, R-02
H03: three-generation household in Box Elder; prefers Spanish	D-15, D-04, A-02, R-03
H04: shift worker in Portside; shuttle ends before the last shift	A-04, D-14, R-03
H05: single parent in West Commons; two children, two schools	A-01, D-07, D-04

Test household (Reading 1)	Entries most involved
H06: business owner in South Yards; address and parcel don't match	D-06, D-07, D-08

City-county departments

D-01 Mayor / County Executive's Office

Runs and holds: the administration's agenda, executive orders and appointments. Appoints the County Court's judges (A-07) and the Health and Hospital Authority's board (A-08).

Limits: can direct departments within adopted rules. Cannot make an outside agency join, or spend money the council hasn't approved.

Pressure: its name goes on the launch. Because it appoints the court's judges and the hospital's board, any request it makes of either can look like an order.

Questions for the spec: Who approves the system, and who can shut it down? Who answers publicly when it fails?

Works with: D-02, D-03, D-09 and every outside agency. **Start with:** Reading 2; Reading 4 (governance decisions).

D-02 City-County Council and Budget Committee

Runs and holds: ordinances, budgets, hearings and their records.

Limits: passes laws and budgets, after public process.

Pressure: has approved no money for any of this. Its members answer to neighborhoods as different as High Prairie (median household income $151,200) and Colfax East ($58,900).

Questions for the spec: Who pays the yearly running cost, and who benefits? What should the ordinance require the system to do, and what should it forbid?

Works with: D-01, D-03, D-08, D-15. **Start with:** Reading 1 (Table 3); Reading 4 (money and incentives).

D-03 City Manager / Administration

Runs and holds: day-to-day administration, staffing and performance tracking across departments.

Limits: assigns staff and coordinates departments; cannot create positions the budget doesn't fund.

Pressure: if the class designs a system that nobody is assigned to operate, the job lands here.

Questions for the spec: Who runs the exchange day to day? Who takes over if a vendor fails?

Works with: D-01, D-08, D-09 and all departments. **Start with:** Reading 4 (ownership and operations).

D-04 Human Services

Runs and holds: county administration of state-supervised benefits such as food and cash assistance, and the case files that go with them, kept under state and federal rules.

Limits: designs local intake and casework. Cannot change state or federal eligibility rules or open the state's records.

Pressure: a city promise to "simplify benefits" still has to pass state rules and protect appeal rights.

Questions for the spec: Which facts could the county check through the exchange instead of asking the resident again? Who decides when two records disagree?

Works with: A-05, D-05, D-07, D-15, R-01. **Start with:** Reading 1 (conditions 1, 2 and 6; households H01, H03, H05); Reading 2 (county-administered benefits).

D-05 Housing Division (EDHD)

Runs and holds: city-funded rent and homelessness-prevention help, housing policy, financing for housing development and preservation, and tenant and homeowner services; local assistance cases and housing finance agreements.

Limits: runs city programs that have legal authority and council funding. Cannot commit the Regional Housing Authority's vouchers, properties, staff or records.

Pressure: residents come to it for help the Housing Authority controls. Its own rent help is a limited city grant, and it cannot promise a federal voucher.

Questions for the spec: Which overlaps with the Housing Authority are coordination problems, and which need separate authority? What would it want from the County Court when a household faces eviction?

Works with: A-06, A-07, D-04, D-07, R-01. **Neighborhoods:** Colfax East and South Yards (the highest rent burdens), Box Elder, Central Station. **Start with:** Reading 3; Reading 1 (condition 1; household H01).

D-06 Planning, Building and Land Use

Runs and holds: plans, zoning, permits and building review, and their records.

Limits: proposes plans and zoning for adoption; issues permits under adopted rules.

Pressure: growth is outrunning water capacity, and some of the land developers want sits under airport approaches.

Questions for the spec: Can a permit go ahead while an address or parcel record is being corrected? What must the Water and Sewer Authority confirm before new housing is approved?

Works with: D-07, D-08, A-03, D-14, R-02. **Neighborhoods:** Manila and High Prairie (fast growth), Harback (annexation disputes), Box Elder (floodplain), South Yards. **Start with:** Reading 1 (real geography; conditions 3, 5 and 9; household H06).

D-07 Address Office and GIS

Runs and holds: the city-county's official address and parcel registry, and the process for correcting it. Almost every other entry will need this registry.

Limits: maintains and corrects city records. Cannot change postal, school, utility or court addresses held by others.

Pressure: fast subdivision means farm addresses, new parcels and apartment complexes often don't match across the county map, the postal service, tax rolls, utilities and schools.

Questions for the spec: Whose record counts when two disagree? What happens to a case while an address is disputed? Who gets told when an address is corrected?

Works with: D-06, D-08, D-10, A-01, A-03, R-02. **Neighborhoods:** Old Watkins (rural addresses), Inboden (subdivisions), South Yards. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 2; households H02, H05, H06).

D-08 Finance, Tax, Assessor and Procurement

Runs and holds: revenue, property assessment, tax rolls and purchasing; contracts.

Limits: compares costs and sets purchasing procedures for approval.

Pressure: every new service adds a yearly running cost, and none is funded. A fee proposed in class is not law until it is adopted.

Questions for the spec: What does the city build, buy or rent, and what does it own outright? How could it leave a vendor? What does the system cost each year?

Works with: D-02, D-03, D-07, D-09. **Start with:** Reading 2 (institutional models); Reading 4 (money and incentives).

D-09 Digital Service and Records

Runs and holds: the city-county's technology, digital services and records management; system logs and technical documentation.

Limits: proposes system designs and runs tests.

Pressure: it is the obvious candidate to run whatever the class designs, on staff and money nobody has approved. Not every resident has a phone.

Questions for the spec: Who operates the exchange: this department, a new authority, or a contractor? What does a member need to join? What gets logged, and who can read the logs?

Works with: D-03, D-08, D-15 and every outside agency. **Start with:** Reading 2 (X-tee and Athumi in the models table); Reading 4 (information).

D-10 Police, 911 and Emergency Management

Runs and holds: police, 911 dispatch and emergency planning; call records and incident reports.

Limits: sets dispatch and emergency requirements.

Pressure: dispatch needs an exact location fast, and in the north and east the nearest unit can be far away. It should not receive medical data or gate codes it has no authority to hold.

Questions for the spec: What must still work when the exchange is down or a partner has refused? What may dispatch see, and for how long?

Works with: D-07, D-11, A-08, A-09. **Neighborhoods:** Harback and the north and east. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 7).

D-11 Fire Department

Runs and holds: fire suppression, rescue and medical first response across the city-county; incident, inspection and first-response patient records.

Limits: sets fire and first-response operations and inspection requirements.

Pressure: a wrong address costs minutes, and in Harback or High Prairie the drive is already long.

Questions for the spec: Does the Fire Department or the Health and Hospital Authority run ambulance transport? How does a patient record pass from the first responder to the hospital?

Works with: D-10, D-07, D-06, A-08. **Neighborhoods:** Harback, Northfield and High Prairie (low density); South Yards (industrial sites). **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 7).

D-12 Public Health

Runs and holds: population health programs and disease surveillance; disease reports.

Limits: runs city public health programs. Has no say over hospitals' records.

Pressure: it needs hospitals to report cases, and many of the residents it serves have trouble getting to care at all.

Questions for the spec: What may hospitals report to Public Health, for what purpose, and how is it protected?

Works with: A-08, A-09, D-04, D-10. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 7).

D-13 Parks, Recreation and Cultural Affairs

Runs and holds: parks, recreation programs, and the city's dealings with The Hangar, Aerotropolis Park and EDPAC; registrations and facility bookings.

Limits: proposes programs and operating budgets.

Pressure: its facilities cluster downtown, far from the north and east, and front-desk staff already get asked for help with every other city system.

Questions for the spec: Is a recreation pass a sensible first service? What should a resident have to prove to register, given households like H02 and H06 whose addresses don't match?

Works with: A-02, D-07, D-14. **Start with:** Reading 1 (civic and cultural anchors).

D-14 Transportation and Public Works

Runs and holds: city streets, local mobility programs, snow and storm response and drainage; asset inventories and work orders.

Limits: operates city streets and city mobility programs. Cannot run RTD routes or set RTD fares.

Pressure: it owns the streets but not the buses, and the scenario's rail hub doesn't mean RTD has agreed to anything.

Questions for the spec: What can the city offer riders if RTD shares only public timetables?

Works with: A-04, D-06, D-13, R-03. **Neighborhoods:** Portside and the north and east (infrequent service); Box Elder (drainage crossings). **Start with:** Reading 1 (conditions 4 and 9; household H04); Reading 4 (regional transit example).

D-15 Clerk, Civil Rights and Appeals

Runs and holds: public records, language and disability accommodation, complaints and appeals.

Limits: proposes process standards and recordkeeping rules.

Pressure: every automated "no" with no appeal route ends up here as a complaint.

Questions for the spec: Where does a resident go when the system says no? Can residents see who looked at their records? Who fixes a wrong record that came from another agency?

Works with: D-04, D-09, A-07, R-01, R-03. **Start with:** Reading 2 (what the city-county can and cannot require); Reading 4 (information).

Outside agencies

A-01 East Detroit Unified School District

What it is: the public school district for East Detroit, governed by its own elected board.

Runs and holds: schools, enrollment, attendance boundaries and school transportation; student records.

Pressure: enrollment is shifting fast (West Commons is crowded, Prairie Crossing's high school is filling), and its elected board doesn't take direction from the city.

Could offer: a limited enrollment referral, an address-check agreement, or coordination funding. **Likely refusal:** no access to student files and no automatic school placement.

Questions for the spec: Fixed referral information, a shared address check, or a separate district process?

Works with: D-07, D-04, D-14. **Neighborhoods:** West Commons, Prairie Crossing, Inboden (school access), Quail Run (childcare shortages). **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 8; household H05); Reading 4 (school example).

A-02 East Detroit Public Library District

What it is: an independent library district with its own board and property tax levy. Colorado allows library districts to be governed apart from the city or county; Reading 2 lists a real one, the Boulder Public Library District.

Runs and holds: branch libraries, public computers and internet access, in-person help and programs; library accounts and borrowing records.

Pressure: it is already where people without home internet go for help. If the city sends more of them, someone has to pay for the staff time, and borrowing records stay confidential.

Could offer: in-person help with city services, public computers, staff training.

Questions for the spec: Is the library a help point for the system, a member of it, or both? Who pays for the help desk?

Works with: D-13, D-15, D-09, R-03. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 10; household H03); Reading 2.

A-03 East Detroit Water and Sewer Authority

What it is: the public authority that supplies water and treats wastewater in East Detroit, with its own board, rates and debt. Detroit's split between a regional water authority and the city's own department (Reading 2) is a comparison.

Runs and holds: water and sewer service, connections and billing; customer accounts, service addresses and capacity commitments.

Pressure: it cannot promise water it hasn't secured, and every new housing approval depends on its capacity and on who pays for new pipes.

Could offer: phased capacity commitments, or sharing account and service-address data. **Likely refusal:** no new connections until the infrastructure is paid for.

Questions for the spec: Reading 1 says an account alone is not proof of residence. Should water service addresses be checked against the city's registry?

Works with: D-06, D-07, D-08, D-14. **Neighborhoods:** Harback (wells, septic conversion), Box Elder (flooding), Manila and High Prairie (growth). **Start with:** Reading 1 (conditions 2 and 3); Reading 2 (Detroit's water arrangement).

A-04 Regional Transportation District (RTD)

What it is: the real Denver-area transit authority. East Detroit is one of many places it serves.

Runs and holds: regional buses and rail, fares and schedules; fare accounts and ridership data.

Pressure: it answers to a whole region, not to East Detroit, and won't change fares or open rider accounts for one city without a formal agreement.

Could offer: public schedules, a formal service agreement, or a tested pilot. **Likely refusal:** connecting fare records to a city account.

Questions for the spec: What useful service is left without an RTD connection?

Works with: D-14, D-13, R-03. **Neighborhoods:** Portside (shift work), Central Station (transfer hub), the north and east. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 4; household H04); Reading 4 (regional transit example).

A-05 State of Colorado Human Services and State IT

What it is: the real state agencies behind Colorado's state-supervised, county-administered benefits.

Runs and holds: oversight of benefit programs and the statewide systems that hold eligibility and case records.

Pressure: state and federal law set the eligibility rules, and it won't open state systems to a city without an approved agreement.

Could offer: a test environment, an approved interface, or a waiver if one is legally available. **Likely refusal:** direct access to program data.

Questions for the spec: Which state data could East Detroit request through the exchange, under what agreement? How are appeal rights kept?

Works with: D-04, D-09, D-15. **Start with:** Reading 2 (county-administered benefits; rules for the simulation).

A-06 East Detroit Regional Housing Authority (EDRHA)

What it is: an independent public housing authority with its own commission, serving East Detroit and participating communities beyond it.

Runs and holds: federal housing assistance including vouchers, its own properties and its own appeals; voucher and tenancy records, and federal income verification under HUD rules.

Pressure: vouchers are limited. Every referral to a program with no open voucher or unit makes its waiting list longer.

Could offer: a negotiated intake or referral arrangement, limited status checks where permitted, or partnership funding. **Likely refusal:** handing over federal records, or running a workflow the city dictates.

Questions for the spec: Name one real handoff with the Housing Division, and who funds, authorizes, delivers and reviews it.

Works with: D-05, A-07, D-04, R-01. **Start with:** Reading 3.

A-07 East Detroit County Court

What it is: the city-county's own trial court for smaller matters, modeled on Denver's county court: Denver pays for it and the mayor appoints its judges from merit lists, outside Colorado's state court system. Only Denver has this arrangement in real Colorado, so East Detroit's version is a fictional rule written into its founding amendment. Felonies, family and probate cases go to an ordinary state district court.

Runs and holds: evictions, small claims, civil cases up to $25,000, misdemeanors, traffic, protection orders and city ordinance violations; filings, case status, judgments and protection orders.

Pressure: the city pays for it, but its judges decide independently and it controls its own case records.

Could offer: case status to the parties or their advocates, or notice to the Housing Division when an eviction is filed.

Questions for the spec: Should an eviction filing trigger an offer of help? Who may see a protection order, and when? (Reading 3: an automated referral cannot stop a court case.)

Works with: D-05, A-06, D-15, D-10, R-01. **Start with:** Reading 2 (a city-county court); Reading 3 (federal limits).

A-08 East Detroit Health and Hospital Authority

What it is: the city-county's public safety-net hospital, an independent public authority with a board appointed by the mayor. Modeled on Denver Health, which became a separate public authority under Colorado law in 1997.

Runs and holds: the public hospital and clinics, care for uninsured and low-income patients, and a paramedic service; patient records under medical privacy law.

Pressure: it treats patients who can't pay, so every referral the system sends it carries a cost.

Could offer: referrals, help screening patients for insurance and benefits, or emergency protocols. **Likely refusal:** patient records leaving hospital systems.

Questions for the spec: When may the city ask for clinical information, and what may it never see? How do 911, the first responder and the hospital hand off a patient? Who runs ambulance transport, this authority or the Fire Department?

Works with: D-10, D-11, D-12, D-04, A-09. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 7); Reading 2 (a public hospital authority).

A-09 East Detroit Health System

Optional: takes part only if a student claims it.

What it is: the independent health system already in the scenario: a Level I regional trauma center, aerospace flight medicine and a teaching hospital.

Runs and holds: trauma, specialty care and teaching; patient records under medical privacy law.

Pressure: it runs the region's trauma center and owes the city no participation at all.

Likely refusal: patient records leaving hospital systems.

Questions for the spec: Does a second hospital join the exchange on the same terms as the public authority?

Works with: A-08, D-10, D-11, D-12. **Start with:** Reading 1 (civic and cultural anchors; condition 7).

Resident groups

R-01 Renter and Tenant Advocacy Council

Speaks for renters: 53.6% of East Detroit's households, and nearly half of them pay at least 30% of income for housing. Wants help that doesn't require tax records, and appeals that work. Brings renters' actual cases, including household H01. Can take a formal role in governing the system if the city-county grants one.

Ask the spec: Who gets left out when a service is designed for a homeowner who is comfortable online?

Works with: D-05, A-06, A-07, D-15. **Start with:** Reading 3; Reading 1 (household H01).

R-02 Old Watkins and Agricultural Landholders Alliance

Speaks for longtime owners, farm families and small businesses in and around Old Watkins. Wants rural addresses the system recognizes, protection from drainage problems, and a say before land is converted. Brings knowledge of local roads and parcels that the county map gets wrong, including household H02.

Ask the spec: Who pays when farmland is converted, and who can appeal the map?

Works with: D-07, D-06, D-14, A-03. **Start with:** Reading 1 (conditions 2 and 9; household H02).

R-03 Workers and Disability Access Coalition

Speaks for shift workers, people with disabilities, residents without a smartphone, and people who prefer a language other than English. Brings concrete test cases: the Portside worker whose shuttle stops early (H04), the Spanish-speaking household in Box Elder (H03), and residents who can't come in during office hours.

Ask the spec: What has to work without a smartphone or a same-day appointment?

Works with: D-15, A-02, A-04, D-14. **Start with:** Reading 1 (condition 10; households H03 and H04).

Source

Estonian Information System Authority, Data exchange layer X-tee. https://www.ria.ee/en/state-information-system/data-exchange-platforms/data-exchange-layer-x-tee

Sources for the county court, hospital authority and library district models are in Reading 2.